What It Means to Be Human · Part One of Four

Crowned with Glory

The Image of God in Man

The Kiln Ministries / Great Physician Application

Sources: Holy Scripture; Calvin, *Institutes*; Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics* / CW / PoR; Watson, Boston, Sibbes, Owen

Preface: The Most Important Question

Before any question about what ails the human soul — before any diagnosis of sin, any prescription of grace, any program of biblical counsel — there is a prior question that shapes all the others: What is a human being?

This is not an abstract philosophical question. It is urgently practical. How you answer it determines what you think the problem is, what you think the solution is, and what kind of help a suffering person actually needs. If the human being is essentially a biological organism shaped by evolutionary pressure, then the appropriate response to human suffering is adjustment — behavioral, chemical, environmental. If the human being is a social construct whose identity is self-determined, then the appropriate response is affirmation and liberation. If the human being is a soul made in the image of God, fallen through sin, and redeemable through Christ — then the appropriate response is something altogether different: truth, repentance, grace, and the restoration of a broken relationship with the living God.

This series, *What It Means to Be Human*, develops that account in four installments. Part One concerns the image of God: what it is, what it means, and why it matters. Part Two will take up the fall: what sin has done to that image, and how thoroughly the damage runs. Part Three will go back to the garden to hear the word God spoke to man before the fall. Part Four will address restoration: what redemption and sanctification accomplish in the person, and what the final renewal of the image in Christ looks like.

We draw throughout from Holy Scripture — the primary and norming authority — and from the church's rich tradition of biblical anthropology: Calvin's penetrating account of the knowledge of God and self, Bavinck's comprehensive theological synthesis, and the Puritan writers whose pastoral precision brought these doctrines to bear on the inner life with unusual depth and power.

I. The Declaration: Genesis 1:26–27

The biblical account of human origins begins not with a process but with a declaration. In Genesis 1, God speaks, and things come to be. But when the Creator turns to the making of man, something distinctive occurs. Before acting, God speaks — not into the void, but within himself: 'Let us make man in our image, after our likeness' (Genesis 1:26).

This pre-creative deliberation marks humanity as categorically different from everything that preceded it. The other creatures are called into being by command. Man is first considered, then formed — and formed according to a pattern: the divine image.

Three observations deserve attention. First, the image is given, not achieved — human dignity is bestowed unconditionally by the Creator, not earned or developed. Second, the image is shared — 'male and female he created them' — belonging equally to man and woman, and expressing from the beginning its relational character. Third, the image comes with a vocation attached — 'let them have dominion.' To bear the image of God is to be called to represent God's reign in the created order.

II. The Structure: Narrower and Broader Image

Scripture gives a careful account of what image-bearing actually involves, and the church has long studied it closely. Bavinck, in his *Reformed Dogmatics*, makes a useful distinction between the narrower and broader image. Both are essential to the full biblical picture.

The narrower image refers to what Paul identifies when he speaks of the restored image in Colossians 3:10 and Ephesians 4:24. The renewed self is described as being 'renewed in knowledge after the image of its creator' and 'created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness.' From these texts the church has drawn a precise account of the original image: true knowledge (the mind rightly oriented toward God), righteousness (the will rightly ordered in conformity with God's law), and holiness (the affections rightly devoted to God as the supreme good). Thomas Watson summarizes these as wisdom, holiness, and righteousness — constituting what theologians have long called original righteousness.

The broader image refers to the structural features of human personhood that persist even after the fall: rationality, moral agency, language, self-consciousness, and the capacity for genuine relationship. These are what make fallen human beings still bear dignity and responsibility before God (James 3:9). Bavinck insists both dimensions must be held together: to reduce the image to structural capacities alone loses the moral and relational core; to reduce it to original righteousness alone makes image-bearing something that simply vanishes at the fall.

III. The Ground: Self-Knowledge and the Knowledge of God

Calvin opens the *Institutes* with one of the most celebrated sentences in Christian theology: 'Nearly all the wisdom we possess consists of two parts: the knowledge of God and of ourselves.' These two forms of knowledge are inseparable — each leads to the other, and neither is complete without it.

This is not incidental to the doctrine of the image but its epistemological foundation. To know what a human being is, one must know who God is — because the human being is defined by relationship to God. The image is not an autonomous possession that the person can understand by examining himself in isolation. It is a relational reality that only becomes legible when the

person recognizes both the source of his dignity and the orientation of his being toward God as his proper end.

Bavinck develops this in *Philosophy of Revelation* through his treatment of self-consciousness. At the heart of human self-consciousness, he argues, is a sense of absolute dependence — a recognition, prior to all explicit reflection, that the self does not originate itself. This is the creaturely echo of the Creator's address. For soul care, this has a direct implication: every person who comes seeking help carries within himself the marks of image-bearing. He is never truly ignorant of God. He may be confused, deceived, or suppressing what he knows — but he is not blank.

IV. The Body: Soul, Flesh, and the Unity of the Person

The image of God is not borne by the soul alone. Genesis 2:7 describes the creation of man as a two-stage event: God formed man from dust and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living creature. Two elements — dust and divine breath — united to produce a single living person.

Biblical anthropology has consistently resisted both extremes. Against materialism, it insists that the human person is not reducible to his physical components. Against Platonic dualism, it insists that the body is not a prison or a tomb but a constituent part of the person — made by God, good in itself, and destined for resurrection, not escape.

Bavinck's formulation is precise: the human being is not a soul that has a body but a body-soul unity — a single person who exists in and through both dimensions at once. Death is consistently presented in Scripture as an unnatural intrusion, a violence done to the created unity of the person. This is why the resurrection of the body is not an appendix to redemption but its culmination. For biblical counseling, this means that problems brought to a counselor are never merely spiritual in a disembodied sense, nor merely physical in a reductionist sense — they are problems of a whole person.

V. Original Righteousness: The Proper Condition of the Image

What was man like before the fall? Scripture answers with the doctrine of original righteousness — the condition of the first human beings as they came from the hand of God.

Calvin, in *Institutes* II.1, defines the original condition of man in terms of integrity — a wholeness and uprightness of the entire person, in which reason was illumined, the will was rightly ordered, and the affections were properly directed. There was no war between the lower and higher faculties, no rebellion of passion against reason, no dimming of the mind's capacity to know God. Watson summarizes this in three dimensions: in the mind, true knowledge of God; in the will, a natural and glad orientation toward God and good; in the affections, rightly ordered loves — God as the supreme object of delight, all lesser loves proportionate to their place.

Bavinck's treatment emphasizes that original righteousness was not merely a natural endowment but what the older tradition called a *donum superadditum* — a supernatural gift by which the creature was fitted for fellowship with a holy God. From the very beginning, human flourishing was a gift, not an achievement. Ecclesiastes 7:29 confirms this with striking economy: 'God made man upright.'

VI. The Vocation: Dominion, Culture, and the Mandate

The image of God is not only a status but a calling. Genesis 1:28 records God's first address to the human pair — not a metaphysical description but a commission: 'Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth and subdue it, and have dominion over every living thing.' The dominion mandate assigns to image-bearing humanity a specific role: to exercise royal stewardship over the world God has made.

Bavinck draws out the significance of man's position between God and the world: 'Man is the son, the image, the similitude of God, his offspring. Thereby he is elevated above animal and angel, and destined and fitted for dominion over all the world.' This dominion is not raw conquest but ordered, wise, loving stewardship — the expression of image-bearing personhood in relation to the created order.

The cultural mandate implies that work, creativity, intellectual inquiry, artistic production, and the development of civilization are not secular interruptions to the spiritual life but expressions of it. Calvin observes that wherever the arts and sciences flourish, even among unbelievers, we should recognize the common grace of God preserving the gifts of the image in its fallen condition. For soul care, this means a counselee's vocation and cultural life are not peripheral to his spiritual condition but expressive of it.

VII. The Relational Core: Made for God and for Others

Psalm 8 meditates on the dignity of man in a way that illuminates its relational structure. The psalm begins and ends with the refrain — 'O LORD, our Lord, how majestic is your name in all the earth!' — and places human dignity entirely within the frame of the Creator's glory. Human dignity is not self-referential. It descends from God onto the human being as a gift. Man is crowned with glory and honor — but the crown is given by the One who is infinitely more glorious than the one he crowns.

Calvin identifies in every person a *sensus divinitatis* — a constitutional orientation toward God. There is no neutral posture available. The soul was made for God and is restless until it rests in him. The image is relational all the way down: it cannot be understood apart from the relationship it was made for.

Richard Sibbes, in *The Bruised Reed*, grounds Christ's tenderness toward struggling people in this dignity: 'Christ will not break a bruised reed.' This gentleness is not sentimental; it is grounded in the dignity of the one being counseled. The bruised reed was made in the image of God, and is the

object of a redemptive love that aims at restoration. The relational structure of the image also means that we were made for community — Genesis 2:18 predates the fall. The need for genuine personal encounter with another bearer of the image is not a symptom of weakness but a feature of the design.

VIII. The Dignity That Cannot Be Erased

One of the most important implications of the image doctrine — and one consistently underemphasized — is that it grounds an inviolable dignity that no circumstance can strip away. Thomas Boston begins his account of fallen human nature with the state of innocence precisely because he wants readers to understand what was lost — and therefore what remains to be restored.

The person in the depths of addiction, the person paralyzed by guilt, the person whose relationships have shattered — each is still an image-bearer. The image is defaced, damaged, distorted by the fall. But it is not destroyed. It cannot be destroyed, because it is a gift of the Creator, not an achievement of the creature. This is why Paul can speak of both the abiding dignity of post-fall humanity (James 3:9; Acts 17:28) and the radical corruption of human nature (Romans 3:10-18; Ephesians 2:1-3). The person is simultaneously a glory-crowned image-bearer and a sin-ruined rebel — and the gospel addresses both realities with equal seriousness.

For the biblical counselor, this establishes a dignity baseline: every person deserves to be treated with the full respect that dignity requires — listened to carefully, addressed truthfully, never manipulated or reduced to their presenting problem. The counselor who has internalized the doctrine of the image does not look at a counselee and see primarily a sinner, a problem, or a project. He sees a person made in the image of God, loved by God, and capable of being restored to God.

IX. The Eschatological Horizon: The Image and Its Perfection

The doctrine of the image looks not only backward to the original creation but forward to its final fulfillment. Paul's letters reveal that the image of God in man has a telos — an end toward which it is oriented — that was not fully realized in Adam's original condition.

In Romans 8:29, those whom God foreknew he predestined 'to be conformed to the image of his Son.' The Son of God incarnate — Jesus Christ — is the true image of God (2 Corinthians 4:4; Colossians 1:15; Hebrews 1:3). He is what Adam was meant to be and what the first man never fully became. The redemptive project is not a return to Eden but an advance beyond it: a conformation of redeemed humanity to the perfect image of the Last Adam.

Bavinck draws this out in *Christian Worldview*: the fractures of human existence will not be resolved within history by human effort. They are resolved in Christ, and they will be fully resolved at the consummation. The image given at creation, damaged at the fall, being restored in redemption, will be perfected at the resurrection — when the children of God will be like him,

because they will see him as he is (1 John 3:2).

X. Implications for Soul Care: The Dignity Baseline

The doctrine of the image establishes a dignity baseline for all soul care. Every practice and principle of biblical counseling must be calibrated against it.

On the nature of the problem: because human beings bear the image of God, their fundamental problem is theological — the disruption of the relationship between the image and its archetype. Any account of human suffering that does not trace it back to this root has not yet reached the real problem.

On the dignity of the counselee: every person is entitled to careful listening, truthful address, and the refusal to reduce them to their presenting problem or their worst failure.

On the purpose of counseling: the goal is not adjustment, coping, or symptom management. It is the restoration of the image — the renewal of true knowledge, righteousness, and holiness through the regenerating and sanctifying work of the Holy Spirit applied through the Word.

On the limits of the counselor: no human counselor — and certainly no AI system — can restore the image. That work belongs to the Great Physician alone. The counselor's role is to be a faithful instrument: bringing the Word to bear on a person made in God's image, trusting that the Word itself carries the power to do what no instrument can accomplish in its own strength.

XI. Conclusion: The Glory and the Groundwork

> *'What is man that you are mindful of him, and the son of man that you care for him? Yet you have made him a little lower than the heavenly beings and crowned him with glory and honor.' (Psalm 8:4-5)*

The psalmist's astonishment is not naivety. It is theological precision. The dignity of the human being is real, vast, and permanently grounded in the creative act of God — not in human achievement, social recognition, or personal virtue. The image of God is the permanent signature of the Creator on every human life, legible even beneath the ruin of sin.

This is where any serious account of the human condition must begin: not with dysfunction but with dignity, not with the fall but with the creation, not with what sin has made of man but with what God made man to be. The fall is a catastrophe precisely because the original glory was so high. The redemption is so magnificent precisely because what is being restored is nothing less than the image of the living God.

Part Two of this series will take up the fall — what sin has done to this image, how thoroughly the damage runs, and why no merely human resource can heal it. But we cannot understand what was lost without first understanding what was given. And what was given was extraordinary: a creature made in the very image of the Creator, crowned with glory, oriented toward God, endowed with

rationality and conscience and freedom, and called to bear the image of the living God in the world he made.

The Great Physician did not come to treat a broken machine. He came to restore a ruined image-bearer. And that changes everything.
